

WORKING AT GOD'S ALTAR

Chapter 1:

The Altar in Eden...

God Communed regularly with Adam and Eve until the day sin broke the fellowship, denying access to their Creator.

The Altar served man as a place:

- To sacrifice for sins committed.
- To worship God.
- To hear from God.

Hebrews 11:4 ***“By faith Abel offered to God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain, through which he obtained witness that he was righteous, God testifying of his gifts; and through it he being dead still speaks.”***

Genesis 8:20 ***“Then Noah built an altar to the Lord, and took of every clean animal and of every clean bird, and offered burnt offerings on the altar.”***

Noah’s Altar...

Noah built his altar in response to God’s protection, during a time of unprecedented judgment for sin.

Abram’s Altar...

Abram built his first altar in Shechem.

Abram was a worshipper – and a worshipper cannot survive without an altar.

Genesis 12:7 ***“Then the Lord appeared to Abram and said, “To your descendants I will give this land.” And there he built an altar to the Lord, who had appeared to him.”***

Abram’s altar-building habit served future generations in several ways:

- Each altar serves as a reminder of God's promise to Abram and his descendants for perpetual generations.
- Each altar signifies its importance as a place to find the will of God.
- Each altar serves as a signpost or flag marking the territory of promise.

Abram built altars near trees.

Genesis 12:6 *“Abram passed through the land to the place of Shechem, as far as the terebinth tree of Moreh. And the Canaanites were then in the land.”*

Genesis 13:18 *“Then Abram moved his tent, and went and dwelt by the terebinth trees of Mamre, which are in Hebron, and built an altar there to the Lord.”*

The Altar in the Tabernacle...

The Old Testament Tabernacle contained three altars:

- The altar of Sacrifice – This altar is notable for sacrifice. Romans 12:1 ***“I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service.”***
- The Altar of Incense – This altar is noted for worship.
- The Ark of the Covenant – This altar is noted for hearing from God.

Altars in the New Testament...

In the person of Jesus Christ, God fellowshipped with man.

The New Testament Church created altars in houses, prison cells, courtrooms, public and private places.

Psalm 139:7-12 *“Where can I go from Your Spirit? Or where can I flee from Your presence? 8 If I ascend into heaven, You are there; If I make my bed in hell, behold, You are there. 9 If I take the wings of the morning, And dwell in the uttermost parts of the sea, 10 Even there Your hand shall lead me, And Your right hand shall hold me. 11 If I say, “Surely the darkness shall fall on me,” Even the night shall be light about me; 12 Indeed, the darkness shall not hide from You, But the night shines as the day; The darkness and the light are both alike to You.”*

The Omnipresence of God

He lives in us today by His indwelling Spirit,
Therefore, when we make an altar, He is there.

Practical Application:

Just as Old Testament saints found the path to God through a sacrifice offered upon the altar,

so our path to God was initiated through a willing sacrifice.

Just as Old Testament saints understood they could not approach a holy God empty handed, so we learn to bring the gift of ourselves to God.

Just as God spoke from the lid of the mercy seat in the Holy of holies, there is no substitute for man entering His presence for the expressed purpose of hearing from Him.

Chapter 2:

Four Components of an Altar Service...

Everything we do, our singing, worship and preaching, should find its conclusion in bringing people together around a common altar.

While corporate worship and instruction is a time when the Holy Spirit points out our inadequacies, the altar is where man and God

meet face to face and resolve those inadequacies.

Matthew 11:28-30 ***Come to Me, all you who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. 29 “Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart, and you will find rest for your souls.30 “For My yoke is easy and My burden is light.”***

Main event...

The altar time at the end of the church service should be the main event; it is here that an individual's life can be radically changed.

Four components that set up the altar service as a life changing experience:

- Every church service should carry an element of divine orchestration.
- Every church service should feature the moving of the Holy Spirit upon the praise

and worship and the preaching of the Word of God. 2 Timothy 2:15 ***“Be diligent to present yourself approved to God, a worker who does not need to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.”***

- The key to freedom at the altar is a group of well trained altar workers.

Trained Altar Workers...

There are basically two steps in the development of altar workers who are sensitive to the Holy Spirit and know how to help individuals meet with God and receive an answer to their need :

- Experience
- Training.

In every ministry of the church, mistakes will be made. When mistakes are made at the altar, gentle instruction should be given, as occurs in the direction of any other ministry of the church.

The person who has delivered the sermon has a special anointing upon him/her that should carry over into the altar time.

No one will have a heavier anointing to pray at the altar than the person who has just concluded an anointed message from the Word of God.

In this study, we are going to look at the ministry of altar workers, what they should do to qualify for ministry, and how they should conduct themselves.

No matter how you choose to approach your work at the altar, the ultimate goal is for the person who responds to the Word and Spirit to receive what they need!

(TAKE A BREAK)

Chapter 3:

Altar Work Defined...

What is Altar Work?

The position of an altar worker is one of the many vital responsibilities in the church today.

The phrase “altar worker” declares the place where this responsibility is discharged – at the altar – and what is occurring – work.

Ephesians 6:10-12 ***“Finally, my brethren, be strong in the Lord and in the power of His might. 11 Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil. 12 For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this age, against spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places.”***

What is Spiritual Warfare?

Every person who engages in prayer and/or discipleship of others will be involved in spiritual warfare whether they want to be or not.

If you engage the enemy you should have your armor on and your weapons prepared and ready for use.

Ephesians 6:13-18 13 *“Therefore take up the whole armor of God, that you may be able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand. 14 Stand therefore, having girded your waist with truth, having put on the breastplate of righteousness, 15 and having shod your feet with the preparation of the gospel of peace 16 above all, taking the shield of faith with which you will be able to quench all the fiery darts of the wicked one. 17 And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God; 18 praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, being watchful to this end with all perseverance and supplication for all the saints.”*

What are Attacks of the Enemy?

One of the most intimidating things that a potential altar worker faces is the fear of being presented with a problem they do not know how to handle.

When faced with such a problem, the altar worker should be prepared to do one of four things:

- Pray quietly that the Holy Spirit will give special instructions of how to deal with the situation.
- Listen quietly for the voice of the Holy Spirit.
- Explicitly follow the instructions of the Holy Spirit.
- If the preceding steps have been taken and there is no clear direction, the altar worker should motion to the lead altar worker or pastor to aid in the situation.

Isaiah 54:17 “No weapon that is formed against thee shall prosper; and every tongue that shall rise against thee in judgment thou shalt condemn. This is the heritage of the servants of the LORD, and their righteousness is of me, saith the LORD.”

1 John 4:4 “You are of God, little children, and have overcome them, because He who is in you is greater than he who is in the world.”

2 Corinthians 10:3-6 “For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war according to the flesh.⁴ For the weapons of our warfare are not carnal but mighty in God for pulling down strongholds,⁵ casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ,⁶ and being ready to punish all disobedience when your obedience is fulfilled.”

What are Catchers?

Not everyone who falls down at the altar is slain in the spirit.

When a person is slain in the spirit, it is very possible that not everyone around them is in the spirit, and a bystander can be hurt.

It is possible for certain people to come to the altar for the purpose of falling, faking an injury and suing the church.

Catchers should be aware of the following things:

- Stand close to the respondent, but do not lay your hands on them so as to encourage them to fall.
- Be alert at all times as to what is happening with the person who is being prayed for.
- Do not touch anyone in a sexual or inappropriate manner.

- If the respondent begins to fall, catch them under the arms and gently guide them to the floor.
- Lay a privacy cloth over every person that falls.
- When the respondent attempts to get up, place your hand under his arm and assist him to his feet.
- In the event that the respondent is standing in proxy of another individual, have prayer cloths available for the altar worker.
- Supply the altar worker with a follow-up form at the appropriate time.

The responsibility of being a catcher at the altar is a very important responsibility. Without these important people, many injuries would occur.

Chapter 4:

Goals of Altar Work...

Altar workers should always have an extremely pleasant appearance.

Altar workers should always dress as if they are going somewhere important.

Altar workers should look and smell clean.

The ultimate goal is to aid the respondents in reaching out to God.

Seeking to Discover the Individual's Need...

When an individual responds to the altar call the altar worker should shake their hand and introduce his/her self and say, "Can you tell me what you need from the Lord?"

This automatically:

- Sets the respondent at ease.
- Says you are concerned about his/her problems.

- Lets the respondent know you stand ready to assist him/her.
- Gives the respondent an “out” if they do not feel comfortable discussing it.

Remember, God gives specific answers to specific prayers. James 4:2 ***“You lust and do not have. You murder and covet and cannot obtain. You fight and war. Yet you do not have because you do not ask.”***

Matthew 18:19 ***“Again I say to you that if two of you agree on earth concerning anything that they ask, it will be done for them by My Father in heaven.”***

Daniel 10:10-14 ***“Suddenly, a hand touched me, which made me tremble on my knees and on the palms of my hands.11 And he said to me, “O Daniel, man greatly beloved, understand the words that I speak to you, and stand upright, for I have now been sent to***

you.” While he was speaking this word to me, I stood¹² Then he said to me, “Do not fear, Daniel, for from the first day that you set your heart to understand, and to humble yourself before your God, your words were heard; and I have come because of your words. ¹³ “But the prince of the kingdom of Persia withstood me twenty-one days; and behold, Michael, one of the chief princes, came to help me, for I had been left alone there with the kings of Persia.¹⁴ “Now I have come to make you understand what will happen to your people in the latter days, for the vision refers to many days yet to come.”

Leading in Specific Prayer...

The altar worker must have a keen desire to intercept the needs of others.

The altar worker must be an intercessor.

Spiritual battles can only be fought with spiritual weapons. Ezekiel 22:30 “So I sought for a man among them who would make a wall, and stand in the gap before Me on behalf of the land, that I should not destroy it; but I found no one.”

Ephesians 6:10-12 “Finally, my brethren, be strong in the Lord and in the power of His might. 11 Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil. 12 For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this age, against spiritual *hosts* of wickedness in the heavenly *places*.”

2 Corinthians 10:3-5 “For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war according to the flesh. 4 For the weapons of our warfare *are* not carnal but mighty in God for pulling down strongholds,

5 casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ.”

Chapter 5:

Qualifications for Altar Workers...

Any ministry worth doing should have specific guidelines.

In this chapter we will explore eight qualifications for altar workers.

1) Anyone desiring permission to work at the altar should provide evidence of the new birth.

As ridiculous as it sounds, not everyone who desires to work at the altar has been born again.

Some people have been in church their whole life, and rather than being saved, they have become religious.

Some come from various religions and backgrounds seeking an opportunity to influence individuals at the altar of the church.

2) Altar Workers Must be Filled with the Holy Spirit.

The Holy Spirit is a teacher.

The Holy Spirit reveals the comfort of God.

The Holy Spirit reveals the hidden things of God.

The Holy Spirit reveals the will of God to the believer.

The Holy Spirit prays about things that the altar worker is not aware.

3) The altar worker must be called to this ministry.

For a person to feel called to a ministry we must define the role of one who is called to the ministry. To accept a role of being a minister,

one must first accept the fact that they are called to ministry. this can only happen if we:

- Assist altar workers in realizing that God has an eternal plan for their lives. Exodus 18:13-23 *“And so it was, on the next day, that Moses sat to judge the people; and the people stood before Moses from morning until evening.14 So when Moses’ father-in-law saw all that he did for the people, he said, “What is this thing that you are doing for the people? Why do you alone sit, and all the people stand before you from morning until evening?” 15 And Moses said to his father-in-law, “Because the people come to me to inquire of God.16 “When they have a difficulty, they come to me, and I judge between one and another; and I make known the statutes of God and His laws.”17 So Moses’ father-in-law said to him, “The thing that you do is not good*

18 “Both you and these people who are with you will surely wear yourselves out. For this thing is too much for you; you are not able to perform it by yourself.19

“Listen now to my voice; I will give you counsel, and God will be with you: Stand before God for the people, so that you may bring the difficulties to 20 “And you shall teach them the statutes and the laws, and show them the way in which they must walk and the work they must do.21

“Moreover you shall select from all the people able men, such as fear God, men of truth, hating covetousness; and place such over them to be rulers of thousands, rulers of hundreds, rulers of fifties, and rulers of tens. 22 “And let them judge the people at all times. Then it will be that every great matter they shall bring to you, but every small matter they themselves shall judge.

So it will be easier for you, for they will bear the burden with you.²³ “If you do this thing, and God so commands you, then you will be able to endure, and all this people will also go to their place in peace.”

Jeremiah 1:4-5 “The Lord said to me. 5 “I knew you before you were formed within your mother’s womb; before you were born I sanctified you and appointed you as my spokesman to the world.”

- Reveal who has given the call.
- Provide tools that will help them fulfill their responsibility. Matthew 4:18-20 *“And Jesus, walking by the Sea of Galilee, saw two brothers, Simon called Peter, and Andrew his brother, casting a net into the sea; for they were fishermen.¹⁹ Then He said to them, “Follow Me, and I will make*

you fishers of men.”²⁰ They immediately left their nets and followed Him.”

4) Altar Workers Must be Concerned

No one can be an effective altar worker without a genuine concern for the fate of others.

Do you have the gift of giving?

Do the needs of others affect your life?

When you see a need do you have a desire to take care of it?

When you see a need do you try to get someone else to meet it or do you take care of it yourself?

When you see a need and realize that it will require you to give of your resources to meet it, do you continue to minister or do you disconnect yourself from it? Matthew 16:24-26

“Then Jesus said to His disciples, “If anyone desires to come after Me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow Me.”²⁵ “For

whoever desires to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for My sake will find it.26 “For what profit is it to a man if he gains the whole world, and loses his own soul? Or what will a man give in exchange for his soul?”

5) Altar Workers Must be Committed

An altar worker who believes that they are called of God to be involved in this ministry will commit themselves to do the following things:

- Develop a personal prayer life.
- Read and study the Word of God on a regular basis.
- Fast on a regular basis. Matthew 17:21
“However, this kind does not go out except by prayer and fasting.”
- Attend church faithfully.

6) Altar Workers Must be Submissive

There is no room on the altar worker's side of the altar for "lone rangers".

One of the most important qualifications for those who wish to be involved in this ministry is submission. Matthew 8:5-13 ***"And when Jesus was entered into Capernaum, there came unto him a centurion, beseeching him, 6 And saying, Lord, my servant lieth at home sick of the palsy, grievously tormented. 7 And Jesus saith unto him, I will come and heal him. 8 The centurion answered and said, Lord, I am not worthy that thou shouldest come under my roof: but speak the word only, and my servant shall be healed. 9 For I am a man under authority, having soldiers under me: and I say to this man, Go, and he goeth; and to another, Come, and he cometh; and to my servant, Do this, and he doeth it. 10 When Jesus heard it,***

he marvelled, and said to them that followed, Verily I say unto you, I have not found so great faith, no, not in Israel. 11 And I say unto you, That many shall come from the east and west, and shall sit down with Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, in the kingdom of heaven. 12 But the children of the kingdom shall be cast out into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth. 13 And Jesus said unto the centurion, Go thy way; and as thou hast believed, so be it done unto thee. And his servant was healed in the selfsame hour.”

Altar Workers Must be Submissive to:

- God
- The head altar worker.
- The pastor of the church

7) Altar Workers Must be Loyal

- To God.

- To the Pastor.

8) Altar Workers Must be Confidential

The greatest risk any person responding to an altar invitation faces is that an altar worker will not be able to keep a confidence. James 3:5-6

“So also the tongue is a small thing, but what enormous damage it can do. A great forest can be set on fire by one tiny spark. And the tongue is a flame of fire. It is full of wickedness, and poisons every part of the body. And the tongue is set on fire by hell itself and can turn our whole lives into a blazing flame of destruction and disaster.”

The tongue:

- Has the ability to destroy relationships.
- Has the ability to limit income potential.
- Has the ability to destroy innocent lives.

- Has the ability to tarnish the physical appearance.

When these eight qualifications are followed implicitly, and those who sit in the pews feel secure, the altar call will be a completely different ball game!

Chapter 6:

Techniques for Altar Workers

In this chapter we are going to learn the mechanics of effective altar work and how to help someone “pray through”. In so doing, we are going to look at six vital areas of prayer ministry that every altar worker must become familiar with.

Counseling Session or Prayer Time...

It is not the altar worker’s place to create a counseling session.

The respondent is asking for someone to agree with them in prayer, not to counsel with them.

Time is of the essence.

Altar workers are not qualified counselors.

To persist in counseling those who have responded to the invitation, without the authorization of church leaders, places both the altar worker and the church in a litigious situation.

1) Leading a Person to Christ

- Admit - Romans 3:23 ***“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.”***
- Repent - Romans 6:23 ***“For the wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.”***
- Believe - Romans 10:9-10 ***“If you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised***

*Him from the dead, you will be saved.¹⁰
For with the heart one believes unto
righteousness, and with the mouth
confession is made unto salvation.”*

- Receive - Revelation 12:10-1 *“Then I heard
a loud voice saying in heaven, “Now
salvation, and strength, and the kingdom of
our God, and the power of His Christ have
come, for the accuser of our brethren, who
accused them before our God day and
night, has been cast down.¹¹ “And they
overcame him by the blood of the Lamb
and by the word of their testimony, and
they did not love their lives to the death.”*

Romans 10:17 *“So then faith comes by
hearing, and hearing by the word of God.”*

Proverbs 18:21 *“Death and life are in the
power of the tongue, And those who love it
will eat its fruit.”*

2) Assisting a Person to Receive the Baptism of the Holy Spirit

The altar worker must make certain that the person they are praying for has been born again.

The altar worker must help the candidate understand that, the baptism in the Holy Spirit is a gift. Acts 1:8 ***“But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”***

The altar worker must make sure that the candidate can exercise enough faith to believe in the authenticity of the gift, and more importantly, the giver of the gift.

The altar worker must help the candidate understand tarrying is not a necessary part of receiving this gift. Acts 19:6 ***“And when Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came***

upon them, and they spoke with tongues and prophesied.”

3) Praying for Physical Healing

The respondent must hurdle high enough to believe that God is greater than their pain.

They must clear the hurdle of believing that they can fix the problem on their own, and turn it over to God.

They must clear the hurdle of releasing the hand of human help and securely gripping the divine hand of God while exercising faith in Him as the source of the healing.

They must believe the Word of God is the highest form of reality. 1 Peter 2:24 ***“Who Himself bore our sins in His own body on the tree, that we, having died to sins, might live for righteousness—by whose stripes you were healed.”***

Isaiah 53:5 ***“But He was wounded for our transgressions, He was bruised for our iniquities; The chastisement for our peace was upon Him, And by His stripes we are healed.”***

Psalms 103:3 ***“Who forgives all your iniquities, Who heals all your diseases.”***

We must help the respondent believe:

- Jesus is the Great Physician.
- It is God’s will to heal His children.
- This is their day for a miracle!

Give them the opportunity to identify the problem.

Share a healing Scripture with them.

Anoint them with oil in the name of the Lord.

In some cases stand against the spirit of infirmity.

Encourage them to stand on the Word.

4) Praying for Emotional Healing

Emotional difficulty is widely touted in the medical community and the general population.

Emotional problems are almost totally ignored in the church.

While neither philosophy seems plausible, millions of people around the world are dependent on mind controlling drugs just to get them through their day.

When praying for a person with emotional problems, follow this outline:

- Identify the problem.
- Assure the person that his/her problem is as real as a physical problem.
- Share a healing Scripture with him/her.
- Anoint him/her with oil in the name of the Lord.

- Pray! Bind the power of sickness and disease. In some cases stand against the spirit of infirmity.
- Encourage them to stand on the Word of God.

A very common cause at the root of emotional suffering is un-forgiveness. Matthew 5:23-24 ***“Therefore if thou bring thy gift to the altar, and there rememberest that thy brother hath ought against thee; 24 Leave there thy gift before the altar, and go thy way; first be reconciled to thy brother, and then come and offer thy gift.”*** Matthew 6:14-15 ***“For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: 15 But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.”***

The following things can often be very effective when dealing with an offended party:

- Have the offended go to the offender and ask forgiveness. Sometimes it is not wise to physically approach the offender. When the offender should not be approached, the offended party should write a letter, read it aloud, and then destroy the letter.
- When the offender is deceased, the offended party should follow the same steps.

If a person is dealing with emotional trauma, they should always be referred to the head altar worker or senior pastor.

5) Praying For Children

Matthew 19:15 ***“Let the little children come to me, and don’t prevent them. For of such is the Kingdom of Heaven”.***

Proverbs 2:6 ***“Train up a child in the way he should go, And when he is old he will not depart from it.”***

The following guidelines should be followed when praying with a minor:

- Have a legal guardian or another adult present.
- Treat the child as if they are as important as any adult.
- Talk to and pray for him on a level they can understand.
- Treat their need as one of ultimate importance.

If abuse is discovered, pass the information along to the head altar worker or senior pastor and do not share it with anyone else.

Give the follow up information to the children's pastor or children's worker and make sure that they are contacted.

6) Praying for the Demon Possessed

Ephesians 6:12 *“For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places.”*

Matthew 28:18 *“And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.”*

Luke 10:19 *“Behold, I give unto you power to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy: and nothing shall by any means hurt you.”*

1 John 4:4 *“Ye are of God, little children, and have overcome them: because greater is he that is in you, than he that is in the world.”*

The following procedures should be followed when praying for the demon possessed:

- Bind the enemy in the name of Jesus and according to the Word of God.
- Command the enemy not to speak or manifest.
- Take the person to the prayer room.
- Never go to the prayer room alone.
- No further action should be taken without proper personnel being present.
- No physical restraint should be used.

Chapter 7:

Following Up

Collect Proper Information

The altar worker should be charged with the responsibility of completing the information card.

If a separate prayer room is provided by the church, everyone who has responded to the altar

call should be invited to meet briefly with the altar workers.

Make sure the information card has in fact been completed.

Make contact with the individual within 24 hours.

Offer to meet the individual in the church lobby prior to the next service.

Make Personal Contact

The church should immediately transfer the information card to the church database.

Every person responding to an altar call should be added to the prayer list of the altar worker.

When adding a name to a prayer list the following information is needed:

- Name
- Phone number

- Email
- Address

The specific need of the individual should be noted.

The date of the entry should be noted.

A person should remain on an altar worker's prayer list for a minimum of one month.

Discipleship

All churches who wish to be effective in the business of changing people's lives understand the importance of discipleship.

Discipleship is not in competition with the work that occurs at the altar. It is an extension and continuation of that ministry.

It is absolutely imperative that all churches establish a discipleship program that begins with

the new birth and continues until the individual has received the prize at the end of the race.

When the altar is the most effective place in the church, the front door will be wide open, the back door will be completely closed, and as a result the church will quickly fill up.